

# **Individual Oral (IO)**

# IO Study Guide

## Choosing your Global Issue

### What does the IB actually require?

The IB English syllabus states that you can pick *any* global issue for your Individual Oral, as long as the global issue satisfies all three of these criteria:

- It's pervasive and **experienced all over the world** in (pretty much) every country.
- It has a **big impact** on people.
- It affects people in **common, everyday scenarios** and environments.

The IB provides five categories, like "Culture, identity & community" and "Politics, power & justice".

*According to the current IB English syllabus (First assessment 2021), Global Issues **do not** have to belong to any of the 5 categories. The category is irrelevant; the categories are merely provided by the IB as a **starting point** for you to start brainstorming.*

As an example, the global issue in the [exemplar IO](#) doesn't belong to any of the five default categories. Instead, it belongs to its own category: Economics, ethics and society. And that's fine according to the syllabus.

With that said, here are 25 starting points for a global issue: use this list as inspiration, you'll definitely want to add your own twist and make them more specific to your own texts--they're quite general and vague out-of-the-box.

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### The List

#### Culture, identity & community

- The threat of cultural homogenization in the face of globalized popular culture.
- How forced migration leads to the loss of cultural identity and heritage.
- The harmful effects of social media usage on body image and self-esteem.
- How consumer culture promotes frivolous lifestyles.
- How sporting culture shapes national identity.

#### Beliefs, values & education

- Unequal access to education perpetuating poverty and wealth inequality.
- The impact of propaganda and misinformation on public beliefs and social harmony.
- The harmful effects of extremist ideologies on political division and democracy.
- Social tension caused by conflicts in religious belief.
- How formal education can lead to rigid ways of thinking, limiting innovation and creativity.

#### Politics, power & justice

- The violation of fundamental human rights leading to the oppression of individuals and communities.

- The impact of globalization on the sovereignty of nations and their political systems.
- The perpetuation of social inequality and injustice through political corruption.
- The challenge of balancing national security and civil liberties in the face of terrorism and security threats.
- The effect of systemic racism on unjust and unfair treatment under the law.

### **Art, creativity & imagination**

- Balancing the protection of creative works with the public's right to access them in the digital age.
- The negative impact of digital sharing on the protection of intellectual property rights.
- The impact of censorship on artistic freedom and creative expression.
- The challenge of balancing artistic freedom with social responsibility and cultural / religious sensitivity.
- The restrictions placed by copyright on the free expression of musicians and artists.

### **Science, technology & the environment**

- The impact of climate change on global food security.
- The challenge of balancing technological innovation with ethical considerations and social responsibility.
- The effect of automation and artificial intelligence on employment and the workforce.
- The challenge of balancing economic growth with environmental conservation and preservation.
- Technology companies violating the privacy of individuals.

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## **The IO Mindset**

### **The 2 Mistakes to Avoid**

Looking at students' IOs, there are two crippling mistakes that hurt their marks.

1. Analyzing for the sake of analyzing, without direction, loosely tied to the global issue.
2. Findings in the global issue are not insightful. Surface-level.

Both of these are a symptom of not understanding the purpose of the IO.

They are typing words onto a page because they need to hit a word count, not because they understand why they are doing it in the first place. The goal is obviously to be in the latter case.

To help you avoid these mistakes, let me explain a much better mindset or mental approach to the IO.

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### **The Mindset Shift**

For a moment, forget that you're an English student.

No, instead... you're a researcher. Not a chemistry research, or a physicist, but a sociology researcher trying to discover something new and disruptive about the global, social issue you've chosen.

But imagine for a second, in this parallel universe in which you're a sociologist, that Google and the Internet ceased to exist. As a researcher, your only two sources of information about the global issue are... surprise... the two texts you've chosen.

Your job as the researcher (after all, you're gunning for a Nobel Prize) is to discover something monumental, something groundbreaking, something interesting that no one has ever thought of before about the global issue that you're researching...

That is your job.

Now, applying this metaphor back to the IO... that's what you're trying to do. You're not just writing about some texts about some global issue to meet some word count. No, you're trying to discover something new about the global issue. You're trying to find real insight into the global issue (at least if you're aiming for the highest marks).

But the catch is obviously that the findings must come from the language and authorial choices.

Put another way, you're kind of a weird sociologist / anthropologist, studying an important global issue. Except you don't directly go out and observe people and communities affected by the global issue (as a normal sociologist might do). Maybe it's a pandemic again. And so you must resort to reading texts (two, to be exact), gaining insight into the real world **via, through the eyes of, through the perspectives** of the authors and the authorial choices they make.

So in short, you are a sociologist that studies social issues from a distance, **using the authors' perspectives and language as a window** into the global issue.

With this renewed mindset and mental approach, Mistakes 1 and 2 (the most common mistakes) are no longer a problem for you:

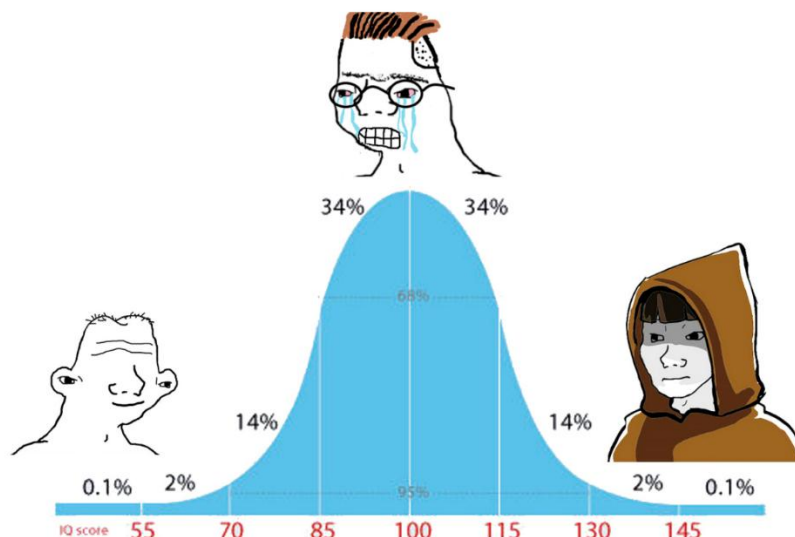
1. Don't analyze for the sake of analysis: Analyze to reveal and uncover new insight into the complexity of the social issue.
2. Try to avoid analysis that leads to obvious, surface-level findings of the global issue. Try to present insightful findings about the global issue which are nuanced, non-obvious, or require additional layers of reasoning.

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### **The Ladder of Insight**

Great. You now understand the right mindset to approach the IO, but it's still a bit vague. To make the road to success even more clear for you, we've come up with the Ladder of Insight.

It tells you exactly how to turn up the insightfulness of your Individual Oral analysis. You can also use this system to decide how insightful your current analysis is, and which parts need improvement.



This ladder will help you climb from left-curve to right-curve.

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### Level 0

**You analyze a scenario that is related to the global issue but don't explicitly explain how it's relevant to the global issue.**

A lot of students are stuck at this level: they just talk about the scenario or evidence, but don't explain the relevance to the global issue.

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### Level 1

**You mention a scenario and link to a global issue, but don't back it up with analysis.**

Let's say our global issue is "social media causes negative self-image in young people".

Here's an example of Level 1:

*"In the extract, the author describes the social media app as a negative influence on teens. He shows that teens are suffering and highlights the significance of the global issue."*

In case you don't know how to analyze properly, check out this lesson: [What is Analysis... actually?](#)

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### Level 2

**You show how an authorial choice demonstrates the global issue.**

Here, you are fulfilling the requirement of analysis, but the findings are not insightful. Most students are stuck at this level.

Here's an example of Level 2:

*"In the extract, the author describes the social media app as a 'horrible' influence on teens, where the critical diction conveys the highly damaging impact of social media on mental health."*

### Level 3

**You show how an authorial choice reveals something interesting and non-obvious about the global issue.**

OK, now we're getting somewhere...

To get from Level 2 to Level 3, it's not just about analyzing more in-depth. An important part is choosing the right ingredients (i.e. authorial choices) that **contain** insight. The example above of 'horrible' is, excuse the pun, horrible evidence because all it allows you to say about the social issue is that "oh, the global issue is very bad".

We want to instead find authorial choices that add a different, or a deeper, dimension to the global issue. Here's how you can tell whether evidence has potential to be insightful or not:

- The evidence shows the global issue in action. (Not insightful: Avoid)
- The evidence reveals something interesting about the global issue. (Insightful: Aim for this)
  - The evidence **explains** the global issue and its **causes**.
  - The evidence **extrapolates** the global issue to extremes to highlight its impact.
  - The evidence **reveals unique qualities** of the global issue.
  - The evidence **reveals solutions** to the global issue.

Here's an example of Level 3:

*“In the extract, the author describes the social media app as a ‘vulture’, a scavenger that feeds off corpses. The description conjures alarming images of these large tech corporations feeding off the attention, time and well-being of young people. The author’s unsettling diction thus adds a far more sinister perspective to the global issue: a predator-prey dynamic between social media and youth.”*

The insight at the end about the sinisterness is only possible because we chose evidence that reveals something interesting about the global issue.

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### Level 3.5

**You weight up the pros and/or cons of an authorial choice in its depiction of the global issue.**

We call this level 3.5, because it's OK to stop at Level 3. If you reach Level 3 consistently in your analysis, then you're doing great. Level 3.5 is the cherry on top, it doesn't always happen. It's where you **evaluate** the authorial choices (weight up pros and cons).

Why is it important to evaluate in the Individual Oral? Recall the mindset shift we talked about at the start of this lesson. You are a researcher trying to glean real insight into real social issues. What if the author of the text is a complete nutjob and has an extremely skewed view of the issue? What if the author's perspective is only half the story? Clearly, our findings are limited by the author's perspective, and we need to acknowledge that fact as researchers.

Common types of evaluation:

- Is the authorial choice effective / ineffective at presenting the global issue?
- Does the authorial choice reveal bias, unreliability or fairness in the author's perspective on the global issue? Can the author's perspective be trusted?

- Does the authorial choice add nuance and perspective to the global issue?
- And the list goes on...

Here's an example of Level 3.5 insight, continuing from Level 3's example:

*“In the extract, the author describes the social media app as a ‘vulture’, a scavenger that feeds off corpses. The description conjures alarming images of a these large tech corporations feeding off the attention, time and well-being of young people. The author’s unsettling diction thus adds a far more sinister perspective to the global issue: a predator-prey dynamic between social media and youth. **The author uses the morbid imagery to create a sickening effect, triggering in the reader a powerful, emotional disdain towards Big Tech’s role in harming young people.**”*

You could also evaluate it in the opposite direction:

*“In the extract, the author describes the social media app as a ‘vulture’, a scavenger that feeds off corpses. The description conjures alarming images of a these large tech corporations feeding off the attention, time and well-being of young people. The author’s unsettling diction thus adds a far more sinister perspective to the global issue: a predator-prey dynamic between social media and youth. **However, the strong imagery can portray an overly pessimistic view of technology in the lives of young people, and perhaps paints Big Tech in an overly dramatic villain-like way that doesn’t stand up to reality.**”*

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### Three pieces of advice

The **perfect IO paragraph** would have: Analysis (Criterion B), Insight (Criterion A), and Evaluation (Criterion B). This doesn't happen all the time, but it's a great ideal to strive for.

Managing to find something new, while connecting it to an authorial choice, while evaluating it, while keeping it concise and within the time limit... Now that's a difficult task, and it takes time. You might not be able to get to Level 3.5 and stay within the word limit, but getting to Level 3 is fine.

Insight and flow state are closely linked. Not many people talk about this. Sometimes, I feel like I have the brain of a snail, and everything I write SUCKS! And sometimes, typically in the evening, at 8pm, things are far easier. I can see connections better, things I thought were impossible mental tasks became manageable. Take advantage of the flow state by finding out at which times during the day you're most creative and perceptive. It's like a natural Limitless window. Tap into that!

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## Choosing the Optimal IO Structure

### Requirements

The structure of your IO (like any other essay or speech) needs to fulfill two requirements:

- It needs to be organized and focused
- It needs to be balanced

### Organized and focused

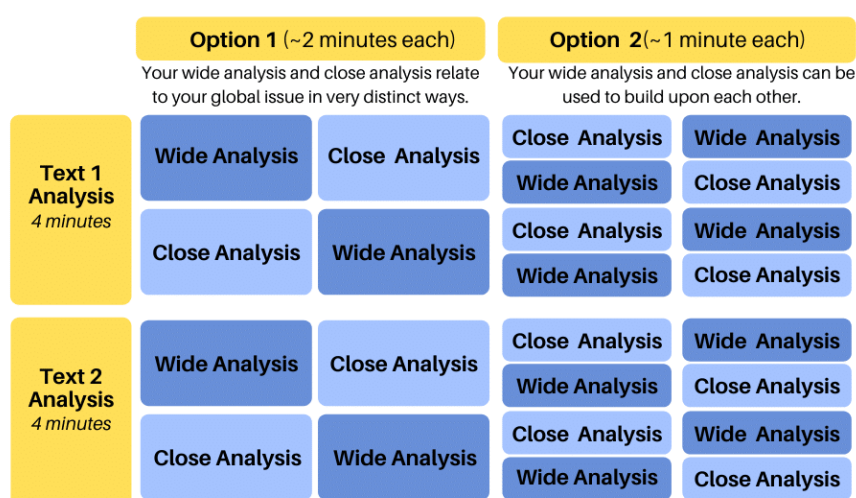
You're not just rambling about random ideas. You show the teacher that you've actually thought about the logical links and the logical order of your points. There is a reason why you present your first point before your second point, and so on. It's not just randomly put together with no rhyme or reason.

### Balanced

You need to spend a similar amount of time on the first text and the second text. You want to show a balanced understanding of the details of the extract (close analysis) and the overall, bigger picture of the text (wide analysis). Thus, you need balance at the level of balancing your word count on texts, as well as balance within a text. Perfect 50-50 is hard to achieve, but it's recommended to find a 50-50 to 60-40 balance in both these aspects.

## Recommended structures

To satisfy these two requirements of the IO, we recommend two different structures to achieve these two requirements of a strong structure. There's no single correct structure to use, the choice depends on the nature of your evidence and how logically related your close and wide analyses are to each other.



IB English IO example: How to structure analysis based on close and wide analysis in an alternative fashion.

The exemplar IO script uses Option 2, weaving close and wide analyses in an elegant tapestry of logic. The IO script demonstrates how to maximize Criterion C by keeping the Individual Oral flowing naturally by smoothly transitioning between the close and wide analysis sections.

## What is close analysis?

We've explained this in the basic Individual Oral Explained guide, but recapping here, it's basically normal analysis like in Paper 1 where you focus on the intricate details of the extract, analyzing the language, visual techniques, etc. depending if you're in Lit or Lang Lit.

## Example of Close Analysis from Exemplar

*First, let's look at the extract from Scene 3 of 'Mother Courage and Her Children', where Mother Courage is selling her wares in a war zone. Her son Swiss Cheese is kidnapped by enemy soldiers, and they request a ransom in exchange for his life. In line 2, Courage yells: "Now run, and no haggling [of the ransom]!" The imperative language and exclamation create an anxious tone, revealing the mother's initial desperation to save her son at any cost. However, after realizing a financial miscalculation, she shockingly haggles the ransom in line 21 by offering "one hundred and twenty, or the deal's off." The business diction and the dismissive tone in "the deal's off" suggest that Mother Courage now sees her son's life as just another business deal. The juxtaposition in her tone*



*characterizes Courage as an extremely ruthless capitalist who will readily risk her son's life to save money. This is an extreme portrayal of selfishness, and Brecht effectively uses it to grab the attention of the audience through shock. The use of motherhood here is also interesting, as it shows that something as primal as the maternal instinct can be corrupted so quickly, underscoring how dehumanizing a capitalist philosophy can be.*

What makes this close analysis?

- We're focusing only on the extract.
  - We're using detailed evidence about the language found in the extract.
  - We're still analyzing, i.e. connecting technique to purpose to effect.
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### What is wide analysis?

You may have heard of wide analysis as “Macro” or “Zooming out”. This section may be the hardest to nail as it can seem new in your IB English journey. Wide analysis is all about using techniques and ideas from *{ " " }* *outside of your extract* which is why you would want to avoid referencing quotes here. This can be done in two flexible ways where you analyze an image or recurring motif, theme, or technique that appears:

1. Outside your extract, but still in your chosen text.
2. Outside your extract, and from another text of your author. This is mainly appropriate when your chosen text is from a collection (e.g., poem collection, photography collection, or a novel containing different short stories), and you are analyzing recurring themes and concepts. If you are doing this, it is ideal to say in the introduction that your text is from a collection.

Ultimately, when understanding the *difference between wide and close analyses*, it's not about *how* you analyze but *what* you analyze. And while it is important to demonstrate your knowledge on both the entire text and extract, ensure that everything still relates back to your global issue.

### Example of Wide Analysis from Exemplar

*Moving to the text as a whole, Brecht continues to portray the selfish capitalist in an extremely harsh light. This is achieved by contrasting the selfishness of Mother Courage against the opposite virtue of selflessness. Brecht uses the character of her daughter Katrin to represent selfless compassion throughout the play. In Scene 11, Katrin bravely risks her life to save the children of a town from a murderous ambush. Also, in Scene 6, Katrin rushes into a burning building to save a baby. Contrastingly, in the same scene, her mother selfishly lets an amputee bleed so that she doesn't waste her precious officer's shirts. So the purity and goodness of Katrin establishes a moral baseline with which to compare Courage's cold, capitalist behavior. Therefore, by using antithetical characterizations of Mother Courage and Katrin, Brecht amplifies the audience's distaste for the capitalist's ruthless, self-centered way of life.*

What makes this an example of wide analysis?

- Looking at patterns across the entire work.
- We're still analyzing i.e. connecting technique (characterization & juxtaposition) to purpose to effect

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## Picking structure 1 or 2

So, after learning about close analysis and wide analysis, how do we use this in an IO speech? Well, this would depend on your chosen texts and the evidence you've selected. If your wide and close analyses relate to your global issue quite differently, it would make sense to separate them into two main sections (Option 1).

On the other hand, if your wide and close analyses relate to the global issue similarly it would be effective to weave these parts together (Option 2). Remember that the time you spend on the wide analysis and close analysis should 50-50 to 60-40 as an IO should be **balanced**.

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## IO Checklist

### Wasted time

Writing your IO can be highly inefficient. aka a huge time-waster.

Because there are *so* many decisions to make, and it's *so* easy to mess up any single one of them.

For example:

- You pick bad text combinations...
- You pick bad extracts that don't have enough juicy material for analysis...
- Your global issue doesn't really gel with the chosen extracts...
- You chose the wrong quotes...
- Your close and wide analysis are unbalanced because of uneven amounts of evidence...
- ... and so on

So how do we make our lives as easy as possible?

### Plan properly!

In dating, you need to evaluate your options--thoroughly!--before committing to a long-term partner. The same applies to your IO.

So use this [planning template](#) (make a copy of the Google Doc) and the checklist below to make sure your Individual Oral is *marriage material*.

It's especially painful when you dedicate *days* to your Individual Oral, only to get stuck in a couple small parts, and have to *restart* the whole thing with new extracts... or even new texts... 🤔

Get some quick inspiration from the plan of the exemplar IO using the same planning template.

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## The 14-point Checklist

aka the "Should I Dump or Marry this IO?" checklist

Start from the top of the checklist and make your way down it.

1. You're happy with your global issue.

2. Your extracts clearly demonstrate the global issue without excessive justification or mental gymnastics
3. Your extracts are not too short or too long. Ideally between 20 to 30 lines for textual extracts.
4. Close Analysis: Your extracts contain juicy literary and non-literary techniques (See Techniques - Levels 1 to 4)
5. Wide Analysis: Other sections of your text / body of work clearly demonstrate the global issue as well.
6. You've decided on 3 to 4 pieces of evidence from each extract for close analysis, and they *all* contain juicy techniques.
7. You've decided on 3 to 4 pieces of evidence from each extract for wide analysis (and ideally there are some authorial choices here too).
8. The chosen evidence from the extract are distributed quite evenly throughout the extract.
9. Each piece of evidence demonstrates some aspect of the global issue without excessive justification.
10. Inter-text Balance: You have roughly the same amount of evidence for Text 1 and Text 2
11. Intra-text Balance: For each text, you have chosen roughly the same amount of evidence from inside the extract and outside the extract. 60-40 split is OK, as there tends to be more evidence from the extract.
12. **Important:** Each piece of evidence you've selected can be analyzed to at least Level 2 on the [Ladder of Insight](#).
13. **Ideally:** Most of your evidence can be analyzed to a Level 3 or 3.5 on the Ladder of Insight. This is hard to achieve, but it'll set you up for complete IO domination.
14. **Optional:** There is some relationship between the close analysis evidence and the wide analysis evidence, to help make the transition between close and wide analysis smoother, bumping up Criterion C: Organization (e.g. if my close analysis focused on metaphors, it would be nice / smooth for the wide analysis to also be about metaphors or something else that's related).

I recommend moving forward with your IO only if 10 of the above points are checked-off. And if you don't have time, ignore all of this advice and just get the IO done before your deadline.

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## Add Insight & Evaluation to Close Analysis

In this tutorial, we're going to level up this close analysis. Note that in this example we are focusing only on the first minute of a full 2-minute close analysis for the extract.

**Global Issue:** "Under capitalism, people sometimes act selfishly in the ruthless pursuit of money, leading to devastating effects on the wellbeing of others"

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### Authorial choice demonstrates global issue

Color code:    *Evidence*    Analysis    **Link to Global Issue**    Evaluation

*“First, let's look at the extract from Scene 3 of 'Mother Courage and Her Children', where Mother Courage is selling her wares in a war zone. Her son Swiss Cheese is kidnapped by enemy soldiers, and they request a ransom in exchange for his life. In line 2, Courage yells: “Now run, and no haggling [of the ransom]!” The imperative language and exclamation create an anxious tone, revealing the mother's initial selflessness to save her son at any cost. However, after realizing a financial miscalculation, she shockingly and selfishly haggles the ransom in line 21 by offering “one hundred and twenty, or the deal's off.” The business diction and the dismissive tone in “the deal's off” suggest that Mother Courage now selfishly sees her son's life as just another business deal. The sudden change in tone characterizes Courage as an extremely ruthless capitalist who will readily risk her son's life to save money.”*

This example is pretty good already, because we're linking an authorial choice ("the sudden change in tone" and "characterization") to the global issue, while using relevant keywords sprinkled throughout.

But there are two things missing from this link:

1. It's not adding a new perspective or implication about the global issue; and,
2. It's not evaluating the effectiveness of the author's choices.

We need these two elements to really step things up and WOW your teacher.

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## Level up to IB7

### Add Insightful Implication & Evaluation

One thing that strikes me as particularly unique here is how **extreme** this scenario is that Brecht paints for us. Let's dig into that.

### A meta / evaluative comment on this extreme perspective

the perspective that the author portrays is extreme. There are far less extreme and more relatable examples of selfishness that Brecht could have used, but he chose to go full HAM on this.

### Evaluation of using this extreme perspective

- Pro: The extreme portrayal is shocking, attention-grabbing, unambiguous in criticism
- Con: the extreme portrayal might distance the audience from the play

### Global issue implication about the *corrupting power of capitalism*

The people aren't necessarily bad 24/7, it's just that capitalism and its corrupting incentives turn good people into bad, greedy people

### Improved version

Now let's put these insights into word form!

*... business diction and the dismissive tone in “the deal's off” suggest that Mother Courage now sees her son's life as just another business deal. **This is a rather extreme perspective on the global issue, as Brecht chooses an extreme example of selfishness—a mother selfishly abandoning her child for financial incentive. While it might distance the audience from the play, it's nevertheless shocking, attention-grabbing, allowing Brecht to unambiguously criticise capitalism for turning caring humans into heinous creatures.***

Notice the subtle sentence structure "While <insert con>, <insert pro>", which helps signpost to the teacher that you're talking about evaluation of the extract.

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### Phrases to use for evaluation

- "the author uses \_\_\_\_ to effectively \_\_\_\_"
  - "however, the use of \_\_\_\_ is not as effective as it could be, because \_\_\_\_"
  - "while a strength of this technique is \_\_\_\_, it also leads to <insert con>"
- 

## Avoid boring links to Global Issue

In this tutorial, we're going to level up a rather boring link to the Global Issue.

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### Boring link to Global Issue

*"Moving on to the non-literary work, investor Mark Baum sits with a financial manager in a restaurant to learn about the soon-to-collapse mortgage bond industry. Audiences expect this manager to be morally responsible and at least somewhat concerned about the interests of his investors, but when Baum asks whether he is worried about the rising economic risks, the manager leans in and says: "I assume no risk from these products myself, Mark". Using situational irony, here McKay portrays a **shamelessly amoral, selfish financier** who considers only his own gain. To make the viewer even more shocked and disgusted, McKay uses a close, over-the-shoulder shot focusing directly on the facial expressions of the manager. The manager confidently delivers the dialogue with a straight face and holds direct eye contact with Baum, showing no shame for this brazenly unethical attitude. **McKay alerts us to the alarming idea that some individuals in charge of our financial systems are extremely selfish.**"*

This link to the global issue is very obvious and not insightful. It doesn't reveal anything new about the global issue: how it's caused, why it happens, solutions, etc.

A much better implication for the global issue is to dig into the idea of the **shamelessness**.

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### Brainstorming a better link

Let's listen in on the conversation going on in my brain when I'm brainstorming a better link to the global issue:

1. "Yes, of course the guy is selfish and unethical. That's obvious and boring."
2. "But why did McKay highlight the shamelessness?"
3. "Could it be that the shamelessness reveals that it's sort-of OK to talk like this in private on Wall St?"
4. "Oh wow, maybe McKay hints at a toxic, ruthless culture that permits this kind of shameless self-interest."

5. "Oh wow, this means that the global issue is such a big problem because selfish capitalists positively reinforce each other through a toxic culture where selfish and unethical conduct is not socially shamed".

### Creating wow moments

When you're brainstorming for your own IO, aim to hit a couple "Oh Wow" moments, because that means you're on the right track: you're finding interesting, non-obvious insights into the global issue. You're kind of like a researcher... but instead of analyzing tiny bacteria or nanoparticles or petri dishes, you're analyzing texts about social issues.

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### Improved link to Global Issue

Awesome. Now let's put this into words. We can even use the phrase "global issue" to make it super explicit and clear to the teacher:

... showing no shame for this brazenly unethical attitude. **Thus, McKay hints at a social factor--a toxic culture--that perpetuates and amplifies this global issue in the modern financial industry.**

This link to the global issue is a lot more insightful, because instead of just being Captain Obvious, we're revealing a **causal** or **amplifying** factor of the global issue.

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### Add Insight & Evaluation to Wide Analysis

In this tutorial, we're going to level up this Wide Analysis. Note that in this example we are focusing only on the first minute of a full 2-minute Wide Analysis for the work.

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Color code:    **Evidence**    Analysis    **Link to Global Issue**    **Evaluation**

### Starting point

*"McKay also uses other kinds of metaphors throughout the movie to more effectively explore the global issue. In one scene, McKay uses a cameo of late celebrity chef Anthony Bourdain. The extended metaphor is set in a kitchen, and the chef compares the complicated idea of shady financial products, specifically CDOs, with the highly relatable and intuitive idea of an unethical chef getting rid of fish through a fish stew, just like how the financiers increased their profits by clumping risky mortgage investments together into a financial stew. The metaphor effectively engages the audience and quickly summarizes the intricacies of how those involved in CDOs acted selfishly to further their own gain."*

This is actually quite a strong bit of wide analysis already, since we have some on-the-fly evaluation of the director's use of metaphor--an authorial choice.

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### Leveling up

But if we had some extra time to spare in the oral, we could step up the evaluation and implications like so...

*"McKay also uses other kinds of metaphors throughout the movie to more effectively explore the global issue. In one scene, McKay uses a cameo of late celebrity chef Anthony Bourdain. The extended metaphor is set in a kitchen, and the chef explains the unethical nature of a financial product*

by comparing it to the intuitive idea of an unethical chef getting rid of old fish through a stew to not waste money. **The cameo and the visual metaphor inject a level of excitement and engagement that simply wouldn't be possible if the explanation was delivered less creatively.** And so McKay **cleverly manages to both educate and entertain** the audience about the global issue. And by using the genre of a conventional dramatic film, inserted with educational scenes, **McKay is able to expose the global issue to a much larger, wider audience** who might otherwise not have learned about the unethical behavior that caused the global financial crisis.”

### What's improved?

Here we're more explicit about the evaluation and praise how "clever" and "creative" the director is in using metaphor.

This line is also quite insightful:

*“And by using the genre of a conventional dramatic film, inserted with educational scenes, McKay is able to expose the global issue to a much larger, wider audience...”*

I like this insight, as it's quite meta and non-obvious.

1. We're commenting on the choice of the **genre** (demonstrating knowledge of the work as a whole)...
2. Connecting it to an unconventional **directorial choice** of educational scenes...
3. And then connecting that to the **implication** of the global issue being exposed to a much wider general **audience**

The implication doesn't apply to the characteristics of the global issue directly, but one level more abstract than that: the characteristics of *audience* that would learn about the global issue via this film. That sounds pretty insightful to me!

Now, try to apply similar logic to your own Wide Analysis to level it up to an IB7.

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## Improving Wide Analysis

In this tutorial, we're going to level up this Wide Analysis. Note that in this example we are focusing only on the one minute of a full 2-minute Wide Analysis for the work.

Color code: **Evidence** Analysis **Link to Global Issue** **Evaluation**

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### Weak example

*Interestingly, this situation is a motif that recurs throughout the work as a whole. In Scene 1, the audience witnesses Courage losing her other son Eilif to the military because she is too preoccupied with a shiny coin. We've already discussed Scene 3. In Scene 11, Courage's daughter is killed while she is away on a business trip. The deliberate repetition constructs Mother Courage as a static character who, ironically, never learns from her mistake of prioritising money over her children. With each loss, the audience pities Mother Courage more and more, to the point where she seems to be a helpless victim trapped in the cycle of greed and grief. **By portraying Mother Courage in an unending cycle of suffering, Brecht persuades us to join him in blaming the global issue on the very system of capitalism itself.***

### Problems

Here the link to the global issue is that "blaming the global issue on the very system of capitalism itself." This implication for the global issue sounds too strong, unsubstantiated by the evidence.

We want to make sure our implications are believable and don't make your teacher roll their eyes. To do this, we need to make sure everything we say is reasonable and a logical conclusion of the evidence.

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### Stronger example

Let's make our implication more believable by adding some more relevant evidence (though we need to watch the word count!).

*We actually see this motif occur again and again throughout the work as a whole. The protagonist loses her children—one by one—because she is too fixated on money. In Scene 1, the audience witnesses Courage losing her other son Eilif to the military because she is too preoccupied with a shiny coin. We've already discussed Scene 3. Finally in Scene 11, Courage leaves her daughter on a business trip, and her daughter is killed by soldiers. The motif constructs Courage as a perpetrator, but it also casts her as a helpless victim, a static character who, pitifully, cannot learn from her mistakes. The same song about persistence and tenacity is also sung in the very first and final moments of the play, which suggests that in spite of all the devastating experiences, she will persist, unchanged. Thus, by using cyclical elements like the motif and the song, Brecht inspires a sense of complete hopelessness and defeat in the audience. **Brecht's pessimistic take on the global issue is this: that extreme selfishness and devastation are simply the eternal, inescapable facts of capitalism.***

### Improvements

- The implication is less strong in claiming the author's intent of "blaming" the global issue on capitalism.
  - We've also identified that Brecht's take is **pessimistic**, which is insightful as it shows you can understand the author's choices from a bird's eye view (exactly what we need for wide analysis).
  - We also use the keywords "**selfishness**" and "**devastation**" from the global issue to reiterate the strong link to the global issue. I also like the use of the word "**inescapable**", as it adds an additional implication: that this sordid mess is just the way capitalism is.
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## Prepare for the IO presentation

### How should I prepare for the presentation?

You guessed it! Practice makes perfect.

How your practice is unique to you.

You may be stressed out on how to make sure you remember *everything* for your 10-minute speech. While writing a script is a great way to organize ideas, it can be a massive drawback if you are not able to memorize it before the deadline!

If you are **worried about not memorizing** your script, here's how you can ensure that you will speak like a total IO expert in your exam:

1. Write your script (of course).



2. Deconstruct your script into a detailed outline using lots of dot points.
3. Practice speaking whilst only using your detailed outline. This method forces you to improvise your sentences on-the-fly without missing the important points.
4. After some time, you need to reduce the number of dot points in your detailed outline and repeat the process until you get down to the [final 10-point outline](#) that you bring into your actual IO.

Using a detailed outline may also help prevent you from sounding robotic and monotonous, which is a common mistake for those who choose to memorize word-for-word.

But no matter if you decide to use a script or outline when practicing, there are several ways you can ensure that you sound **confident, natural, and engaging** during your IO.

Check out Richard's experience and great tips for speaking in an IO:

*What I did was write a script and then rehearse it over and over. Coherency is key and can be marked. You'll want to emphasize keywords and phrases and make your IO engaging and interesting to hear. You'll want to speak loud, sound confident, and enunciate. Remember, a part of the criteria marks your "style (for example, register, tone and rhetorical devices)". If you have a fantastic understanding, analysis and focus but poor language and delivery, you might not be able to get a 7.*

*My first tip for sounding natural is varying your tone, pitch and placing emphasis on important words or syllabuses. Enunciate and stress buzzwords, those important for analysis (i.e. anaphora) or relevant to your global issue (i.e. societal values).*

*My second tip is to record yourself for self-feedback or present it to others. You will personally know how to improve to avoid sounding robotic. And if not, hopefully, the person listening to you can give you pointers.*

*Richard Nguyen, IB45 graduate*

## The IO Conclusion

### What do I say in my conclusion?

The conclusion is where you condense all your findings and insights you've gained about the global issue. You want your examiner to have a lasting impression on your IO so consider different ways to give your conclusion a profound ending.

#### Step 1

First, summarize how the texts have related to the global issue (write around 2 – 3 sentences for each text). Think about how you can combine all your main points in your analysis to demonstrate the author's overall perspective on the global issue.

Here, you want to include the most insightful findings you uncovered during your IO about the global issue.

#### Step 2

Second, compare the two texts in terms of the global issue (if you want!). You may find that comparing the texts can produce a strong conclusive statement on how you explored different aspects of the global issue. Keep in mind that a comparison is totally not necessary, so only spend around 1-2 sentences if you wish to have it.

### Step 3

Third, reflect on the global issue. Similar to step 2, this part is optional but helpful in giving a thoughtful ending to your IO. Your reflection may include a general statement on the global relevance of the issue, highlighting how many authors are prompted to write about it due to its impacts within society.

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#### From the Exemplar

Take a look at the conclusion from the exemplar IO script, quoted below.

*“In conclusion, both works explore the devastating consequences of selfish, ruthless capitalism. (briefly recap the global issue)*

*Brecht **embraces extremes** (top insight) to paint a harsh picture of life as a selfish capitalist. He suggests a depressing, anti-capitalist sentiment that there is **no solution to it** (top insight), that capitalism and its victims are doomed forever.*

*On the other hand, McKay offers insight into the **social factors perpetuating** (top insight) the global issue in the modern financial industry. McKay manages to make the movie **entertaining while also dissecting** (top insight) complicated, but necessary, financial concepts using engaging cameos and metaphors.”*

Here we've fused Steps 1 and 2 together, using phrases like "On the other hand" to signal comparison (optional Step 2). We didn't include Step 3 because the total word count of the oral would be too high.

Notice how the 2-sentence summaries of each text are highlight reels: they contain the most insightful ideas uncovered during the IO.

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## How to Prepare the IO Outline

### General guidelines

1. Order your dot points in chronological order as you would say them in the speech.
  2. Keep your outline balanced like your oral. In the exemplar outline below, each text has four dot points (2 x close analysis and 2 x wide analysis for each text). This means that each dot point corresponds to 1-minute of the speech.
  3. Avoid writing full sentences as you would be tempted to say them word-for-word which would interrupt your spontaneity/flow.
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### Exemplar IO Outline

This is an exemplar 10 dot point outline. For reference, this outline has 165 words.

**Global issue:** the lack of ethical considerations in science can diminish the qualities of a human and lead to societal misconduct.

- (INT): negligence of human dignity to further scientific progress = people either lose or win from scientific development.

- (LIT) Q1/Line#: art theme + societal allusions = imbalance between society's scientific and humanistic principles.
- (L): Student's art creativity/individuality juxtaposes conformity theme = alienation is humanistic = ostensible division between clones and humans.
- (L) Q2/Line#: objectification via anthropomorphism + contrast against prior characterisation = humanistic term "students" is a euphemism.
- (L): Dehumanisation is antithetical to Kathy's humanistic POV (non-chronological timeline) = readers feel sympathy for the mistreated students.
- (NLIT) Q1/Line#: sad diction = associate negativity with unethical research = pathos
- (N) Image: demand gaze from animals = relates unethical science on humans to unethical animal testing.
- (N) Q2/Line#: scientific metalanguage / ethos + encourages scientists (target audience) to self-evaluate = subtle call to action.
- (N): Negatively biased BUT contains reliable sources/point and evidence structure = information is credible and convincing.
- (CON): science misuse creates social division (LIT) + researchers choose vulnerable people for unethical science (NLIT)

## More tips

### How to use abbreviations

Use abbreviations to mark which point corresponds to which section (e.g., INT for introduction, LIT for literary text, NLIT for non-literary text, CON for the conclusion).

### Using numbers

Number the quotes and/or specify the line number to keep track of which analysis matches which evidence. This is also helpful for labelling your close analysis points clearly as the wide analysis points wouldn't have a quote.

### How to represent analysis in shorthand

When writing points about analysis, use + and =. This helps you maintain cause + effect and technique + authorial intent when speaking. General structure: (technique) + (effect) = (link to global issue)

## Staying Motivated with IO

### Why we need to edit

- The Plan is important, but it's only good for checking the overall, big picture direction. Once you start writing the IO in detail, you'll run into issues like:
  - Sounding dumb. The argument which sounded really smart on the plan, actually is pretty lame.
  - Logical holes that you had in your plan

- The analysis for a piece of evidence actually sucks. Not as much depth as you thought.
  - ... and so on
  - So the true process of improving the IO is: Edit! You need to edit to go from lower insight to higher insight. Your first draft will probably start with low insight.
  - How to edit? Create a copy of your IO script, fresh copy. The biggest thing that stands in the way of improvement is the fear of ruining what you already have. Perfectionism. By creating a fresh copy, you can feel comfortable doing anything to it, because your old copy is still there in case your edit messes things up. You can take risks, move things around, it's all fine!
  - Use the comment feature in Google Docs, Pages, etc. to record which Level of Insight each paragraph is at. Ideally, every paragraph should be at Level 2 at least, but ideally at 3, and some at Level 3.5.
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### **How to motivate yourself to edit and improve**

- It can feel tiring, overwhelming to look at your 10th Draft and still see so many areas that aren't at a good level of insight.
- A motivation trick I've discovered is to promise yourself to just do a little bit. Set the goal of simply fixing one single sentence in one paragraph. That's ALL you'll have to do. And combine this with figuring out when you enter flow state during the day, and you'll be able to smash through it. You'll move on to the next paragraph, and the next.
- Even the worst techniques that you think don't have Level 3 or 3.5 potential can actually have it inside them, so don't ditch your evidence before you've really had a crack at improving the insight. I was struggling with improving the insight until I finally looked at the evidence in a new way.

# IO Exemplar

## IO Exemplar Organization Explained

### IO Structure

#### Text 1: *Mother Courage and Her Children*

Close 1 = selfishness of mother

Wide 1 = selfishness emphasised through another technique in the work

Close 2 = devastation

Wide 2 = devastation occurs again and again

#### Text 2: *The Big Short*

Close 1 = selfishness + shameless

Wide 1 = shameless also seen elsewhere

Close 2 = devastation using metaphor

Wide 2 = metaphor also used

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### Why it's effective

#### Cause and effect

Roughly, each text's analysis mirrors the structure of cause-effect: selfishness => devastation. This follows the same structure as the global issue. The only exception is Wide 2 in Text 2, which deviates a little bit from this structure.

#### Linking & Flow

Also notice how each wide analysis part is linked to the previous close analysis part by some logical reason:

- By Idea: e.g. selfishness, devastation
- By Technique: e.g. metaphor

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## Exemplar Individual Oral (IO) Script

Note: This exemplar IO is not an actual transcript, so the vocabulary and sentence structure are stronger than would be expected for an oral.

Also, don't base the length of your points on this exemplar's word count, figure out your own rate of speaking (words per minute), and tailor the length of your points to your rate of speaking. As a rough recommendation, ~1300 words is a good length for 10 minutes. (This exemplar is about 1400 words.)

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### Introduction

The global issue I'm exploring is how, **under capitalism, people sometimes act selfishly in the ruthless pursuit of money, leading to devastating effects on the wellbeing of others.** The literary text I will examine is Bertolt Brecht's anti-capitalist play 'Mother Courage and Her Children', which showcases the damaging effect of Mother Courage's business on her family during the Thirty Years' War. The non-literary work is the dramatic film 'The Big Short' directed by Adam McKay, which exposes how unethical and selfish actors caused the global financial crisis that devastated the entire world.

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## Text 1

### Close Analysis 1

First, let's look at the extract from Scene 3 of 'Mother Courage and Her Children', where Mother Courage is selling her wares in a war zone. Her son Swiss Cheese is kidnapped by enemy soldiers, and they request a ransom in exchange for his life. In line 2, Courage yells: “Now run, and no haggling [of the ransom]!” The imperative language and exclamation create an anxious tone, revealing the mother's initial desperation to save her son at any cost. However, after realizing a financial miscalculation, she shockingly haggles the ransom in line 21 by offering “one hundred and twenty, or the deal's off.” The business diction and the dismissive tone in “the deal's off” suggest that Mother Courage now sees her son's life as just another business deal. The juxtaposition in her tone characterizes Courage as an extremely ruthless capitalist who will readily risk her son's life to save money. This is an extreme portrayal of selfishness, and Brecht effectively uses it to grab the attention of the audience through shock. The use of motherhood here is also interesting, as it shows that something as primal as the maternal instinct can be corrupted so quickly, underscoring how dehumanizing a capitalist philosophy can be.

### Wide Analysis 1

Moving to the text as a whole, Brecht continues to portray the selfish capitalist in an extremely harsh light. This is achieved by contrasting the selfishness of Mother Courage against the opposite virtue of selflessness. Brecht uses the character of her daughter Kattrin to represent selfless compassion throughout the play. In Scene 11, Kattrin bravely risks her life to save the children of a town from a murderous ambush. Also, in Scene 6, Kattrin rushes into a burning building to save a baby. Contrastingly, in the same scene, her mother selfishly lets an amputee bleed so that she doesn't waste her precious officer's shirts. So the purity and goodness of Kattrin establishes a moral baseline with which to compare Courage's cold, capitalist behavior. Therefore, by using antithetical characterizations of Mother Courage and Kattrin, Brecht amplifies the audience's distaste for the capitalist's ruthless, self-centered way of life.

### Close Analysis 2

Coming back to the extract, Brecht explores how this selfishness leads to devastation. At the end of the extract, the sound of drumming creates a gloomy atmosphere, and reveals that the haggling failed and her son has now been executed because of her greed. Brecht also makes the stage dark, and then light again, suggesting that Mother Courage has stayed seated, frozen by her grief. Brecht masterfully combines multiple dramatic techniques—lighting, stage direction, sound effects—to vividly capture for the audience the devastating impact of her selfish behavior. Brecht clearly presents the global issue in an extreme way, using the most extreme consequence of a mother losing her child, in order to convey the extreme dangers of ruthless capitalism. It evokes pathos, provokes the audience to reflect, and makes the global issue far more memorable to the audience.

### Wide Analysis 2

We actually see this motif occur again and again throughout the work as a whole. The protagonist loses her children—one by one—because she is too fixated on money. In Scene 1, the audience witnesses Courage losing her other son Eilif to the military because she is too preoccupied with a shiny coin. We've already discussed Scene 3. Finally in Scene 11, Courage leaves her daughter on a business trip, and her daughter is killed by soldiers. The motif constructs Courage as a perpetrator, but it also casts her as a helpless victim, a static character who, seemingly, cannot learn from her mistakes. So we pity her because she seems doomed to this grim existence forever. The same song about 'persistence' is also sung in the very first and final moments of the play, which suggests that in spite of all the devastation, the suffering will continue. Thus, by using cyclical elements like the motif and the song, Brecht inspires a sense of complete hopelessness and defeat in the audience. Brecht's pessimistic take on the global issue is this: that extreme selfishness and devastation are simply the eternal, inescapable facts of capitalism.

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## Text 2

### Close Analysis 1

Moving on to the non-literary work, The Big Short, we'll look at a scene where an investor Mark Baum has a private meeting in a restaurant with a mortgage bond manager. Baum asks if the manager is worried about his clients' serious risk of financial loss, and the manager answers: "I assume no risk from these [mortgage] products myself". The matter-of-fact tone shocks the audience, as it reveals his complete lack of concern for others, particularly the financial outcomes of his own clients. To make the viewer even more disgusted by this unethical professional, McKay uses a close-up shot focused directly on the actor's straight facial expression as he delivers the dialogue without shame. McKay's shot is also over-the-shoulder, so the manager gazes almost directly into the viewer's eyes, creating an unsettling feeling towards such a shamelessly amoral man. The situational irony is shocking, because viewers do not expect an authority in the financial system to be so shamelessly unethical. McKay's portrayal of the shamelessness suggests this ruthless, selfish mindset is not quite as taboo as one might imagine. Thus, McKay hints at a social factor--a toxic culture--that perpetuates this global issue in the modern financial industry.

### Wide Analysis 1

Looking at the work as a whole, we see other examples of brazenly unethical behavior. In one scene, McKay portrays two mortgage brokers obnoxiously bragging about targeting vulnerable families to make easy money, which reveals that the ruthlessness and shamelessness seen in the manager is an industry-wide phenomenon prevalent throughout all levels of the mortgage industry. Ironically, at the end of the movie, the director depicts the two arrogant mortgage brokers as desperate, unemployed jobseekers. By juxtaposing these characters at their peak and at their nadir, McKay emphasizes how their selfish approach to capitalism is unsustainable and ultimately harms not just everyone else's livelihood but also their own.

### Close Analysis 2

The extreme dangers of this kind of selfish behavior is also explored in detail in the extract. In the last shot of the sequence, a voice-over narrator states that the "synthetic CDO was the atomic bomb". The metaphor directly compares the manager's risky financial product to the most dangerous weapon known to man. The hyperbolic, extreme comparison appeals to pathos, invoking a sense of danger, effectively helping a general audience instantly grasp just how reckless and ruthless financiers were in their pursuit of profit. Towards the end of the scene, McKay also uses fast jump cuts and intense diegetic sounds, like the sharpening of knives and sizzling teppanyaki, to build a chaotic atmosphere.

The viewer feels disoriented, mirroring how precarious the economy had become due to the creation and propagation of these financial weapons of mass destruction.

## **Wide Analysis 2**

McKay also uses other kinds of metaphors throughout the movie to more effectively explore the global issue. In one scene, McKay uses a cameo of late celebrity chef Anthony Bourdain. The extended metaphor is set in a kitchen, and the chef explains the unethical nature of a financial product by comparing it to the intuitive idea of an unethical chef getting rid of old fish through a stew to not waste money. The cameo and the visual metaphor inject a level of excitement and engagement that simply wouldn't be possible if the explanation was delivered less creatively. And so McKay cleverly manages to both educate and entertain the audience about the global issue. And by using the genre of a conventional dramatic film, inserted with educational scenes, McKay is able to expose the global issue to a much larger, wider audience who might otherwise not have learned about the unethical behavior that caused this devastating global financial crisis.

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## **Conclusion**

In conclusion, both works explore the devastating consequences of selfish, ruthless capitalism. Brecht embraces extremes to paint a harsh picture of life as a selfish capitalist. He suggests a depressing, anti-capitalist sentiment that there is no solution to it, that capitalism and its victims are doomed forever.

On the other hand, McKay offers insight into the social factors perpetuating the global issue in the modern financial industry. McKay manages to make the movie entertaining while also dissecting complicated, but necessary, financial concepts using engaging cameos and metaphors.